

ASHISH K VINCENT

VIJU JACOB, 61
Kolanchery, Kerala

Company
Synthite Industries

Net Worth
Rs 1,000 crore
(per own claim)

SPICING UP BUSINESS

Dr Varghese Jacob, popularly known as Viju Jacob, is among the most successful second-generation businessmen in Kerala. His father, C.V. Jacob, founded the Synthite Group in 1972 in a remote village in Kadayiruppu, 26 km from Kochi, at a time spice extraction was unknown in the state. The patriarch passed away in 2021 at the age of 88, but Jacob is determined to continue his legacy.

"We began our journey from scratch and built a quality global brand," he says. "We have survived as the pioneers in the extraction industry for five decades, offering the best products to our clients." Having joined his father's business in 1984, Jacob now has the expertise won from his own 38 years in the industry. Over the years, the business operations have diversified to perfumery, savories, flavours, nutraceuticals and retail.

Spice extraction is a tricky business that demands expertise and innovation to keep up with the evolving global market. Profit margins depend on the quality of service provided to global giants.

A floral extraction plant he set up in Maradur, Tamil Nadu, has today become the backbone of the Indian cosmetic and perfume industry, offering employment to 1,000 families in the vicinity. The organised marigold cultivation he introduced in 1986 on a commercial scale has generated employment for over 14,000 farmers. He has also set up wind farms in Tamil Nadu for power generation. His firm's annual turnover is Rs 2,800 crore and personal assets Rs 1,000 crore.

Now he has diversified into the hospitality sector with the five-star Ramada Resort, and backwaters-facing Riveira Suites, in Kochi. "Diversification is the only way to survive," he says. "The industry dynamics are changing, with new players entering the field and constant changes in technology." Unabashed about his wealth, Jacob owns a fleet of expensive cars, including Porsche, Mercedes Benzes and a Range Rover, and he loves nothing more than night-time driving.

-Jeemon Jacob

ing our over 60 million MSMEs (micro, small and medium scale enterprises) more competitive by helping them digitise, and supporting start-ups as distributed engines of growth will drive greater job creation and more equitable wealth creation as well," Gandhi adds. More businesses then need to be encouraged to build unique playbooks to reduce income disparities.

Is this to say wealth creation is dwindling in our major cities? Not really, say experts—despite the fatigue building up in the bigger cities, wealth creation will continue to grow. What is needed is investment in infrastructure to support the growing population. And that means building up our small towns. Driving income and opportunity growth beyond cities will not only help them breathe, but also end regional disparity in wealth. More power, then, to the Small Town Tycoon. ■